Cool math is hiding in “The 12 Days of Christmas”

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1 Introduction

The classic English Christmas carol ”The Twelve Days of Christmas” has all kinds of interesting mathematical features. First, it is an example of a *cumulative song*, in which the lyrics detail a series of increasingly numerous gifts given to the speaker by their ”true love” on each of the twelve days of Christmas (the twelve days that make up the Christmas season, starting with Christmas Day) [6]. So we might want to know how many gifts are given each day and what the total number of gifts are.

The carol, whose words were apparently first published in England in the late 18th century have a Roud Folk Song Index number of 68 [8]. A large number of different melodies have been associated with the song, of which the best known is derived from a 1909 arrangement of a traditional folk melody by English composer Frederic Austin [9]. There are twelve verses, each describing a gift given by ”my true love” on one of the twelve days of Christmas. There are many variations in the lyrics, however, the lyrics given here are from Frederic Austin’s 1909 publication that established the current form of the carol [7].

The first three verses run, in full, as follows:

> On the first day of Christmas my true love sent to me: *A partridge in a pear tree.*
>
> On the second day of Christmas my true love sent to me: *Two turtle doves, and a partridge in a pear tree.*
>
> On the third day of Christmas my true love sent to me: *Three French hens, two turtle doves, and a partridge in a pear tree.*

The subsequent verses follow the same pattern. Each verse deals with the next day of Christmastide, adding one new gift and then repeating all the earlier gifts, so that each verse is one line longer than its predecessor.

- 4 calling birds
- 5 gold rings
- 6 geese a-laying
- 7 swans a-swimming
- 8 maids a-milking
- 9 ladies dancing
- 10 lords a-leaping
- 11 pipers piping
- 12 drummers drumming

2 How many gifts are received each day and what is the total?

The number of gifts received on day **n** and the total number of gifts received by day **n** are shown in the following table ($1 \leq \mathbf{n} \leq 12$):

Day	Gifts received on day n	Total number of gifts received by day n
1	**1**	**1**
2	1+2=**3**	1+3=**4**
3	1+2+3=**6**	1+3+6=**10**
4	1+2+3+4=**10**	1+3+6+10=**20**
5	1+2+3+4+5=**15**	1+3+6+10+15=**35**
6	1+2+3+4+5+6=**21**	1+3+6+10+15+21=**56**
7	1+2+3+4+5+6+7=**28**	1+3+6+10+15+21+28=**84**
8	1+2+3+4+5+6+7+8=**36**	1+3+6+10+15+21+28+36=**120**
9	1+2+3+4+5+6+7+8+9=**45**	1+3+6+10+15+21+28+36+45=**165**
10	1+2+3+4+5+6+7+8+9+10=**55**	1+3+6+10+15+21+28+36+45+55=**220**
11	1+2+3+4+5+6+7+8+9+10+11=**66**	1+3+6+10+15+21+28+36+45+55+66=**286**
12	1+2+3+4+5+6+7+8+9+10+11+12=**78**	1+3+6+10+15+21+28+36+45+55+66+78=**364**

Table 1: Gift count for the 12 days of Christmas

Interestingly, the numbers in blue in Table 1, the number of gifts received on day **n**, are known as the triangular numbers. The nth triangular number, T_n, is defined as follows:

$$T_n = \sum_{k=1}^{n} k = \frac{n(n+1)}{2} = \binom{n+1}{2} \tag{1}$$

where $\binom{n}{m}$ is the familiar binomial coefficient[1]. For example, $T_{12} = \sum_{k=1}^{12} k = \frac{12 \cdot 13}{2} = \binom{13}{2} = \mathbf{78}$.

So how many total gifts have been received by day **n**? These numbers are shown in red in Table 1. These numbers are known as tetrahedral numbers. The nth tetrahedral number, T_{e_n}, is defined as follows:

$$T_{e_n} = \sum_{k=1}^{n} T_k = \frac{n(n+1)(n+2)}{6} = \binom{n+2}{3} \tag{2}$$

where T_k is the kth triangular number (see Equation (1)).

It turns out that the total number of gifts received is $T_{e_{12}} = \sum_{k=1}^{12} T_k = \frac{12 \cdot 13 \cdot 14}{6} = \binom{14}{3} = \mathbf{364}$.

[1]The great mathematician Carl Friedrich Gauss is said to have discovered the consecutive integer formula (Equation (1)) while still at primary school [2].

A number can be both triangular and tetrahedral. These numbers satisfy the following equation:

$$T_n = \binom{n+1}{2} = \binom{m+2}{3} = T_{e_m} \tag{3}$$

The only numbers that satisfy Equation (3) are [3]:

$$\begin{aligned} T_{e_1} &= T_1 &&= 1 \\ T_{e_3} &= T_4 &&= 10 \\ T_{e_8} &= T_{15} &&= 120 \\ T_{e_{20}} &= T_{55} &&= 1540 \\ T_{e_{34}} &= T_{119} &&= 7140 \end{aligned}$$

Also interesting is the connection to Pascal's triangle [4]. Specifically, the 4th diagonal row of Pascal's triangle (starting from the right side) contains the tetrahedral numbers, T_{e_n}, that is, the 4th diagonal row of Pascal's triangle contains the **Total number of gifts received by day n**. This is shown in Figure 1. Similarly, the 3rd diagonal row of Pascal's triangle contains the numbers we see in **Gifts received on day n** column of Table 1. These are the triangular numbers.

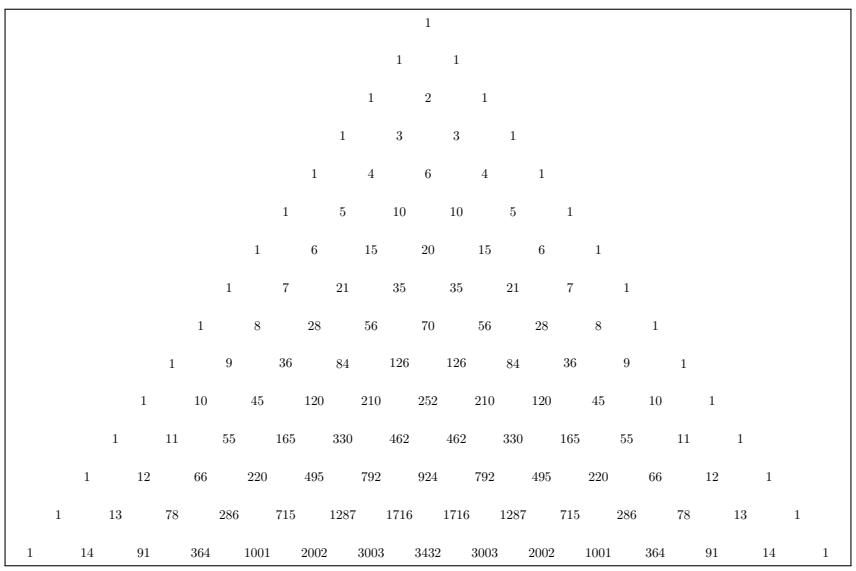

Figure 1: Pascal's Triangle

3 Geometric Interpretations

There are an interesting geometric interpretation of both triangular numbers and tetrahedral numbers. So first, what exactly is a triangular number? The first six triangular numbers are depicted as triangles in Figure 2. We can see from the figure that a triangular number T_n is the sum of the integers from 1 to n

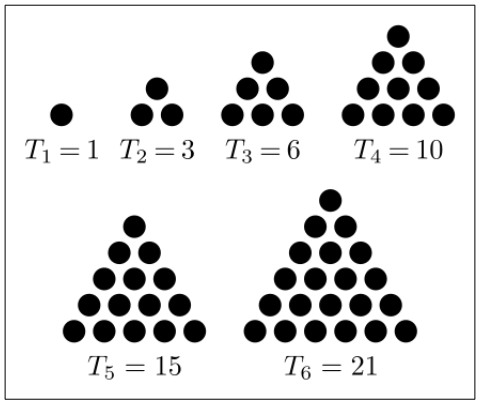

Figure 2: The First Six Triangular Numbers

[5]. This is also the number of gifts received on the nth day of Christmas according to the "12 Days of Christmas".

Next, what are the tetrahedral numbers? As we saw in Equation (2), the nth tetrahedral number is the sum of the first n triangular numbers [1]. For example, T_{e_4} is depicted in Figure 3. The nth tetrahedral number turns out to be the number of gifts received up to and including day **n** in "The 12 Days of Christmas".

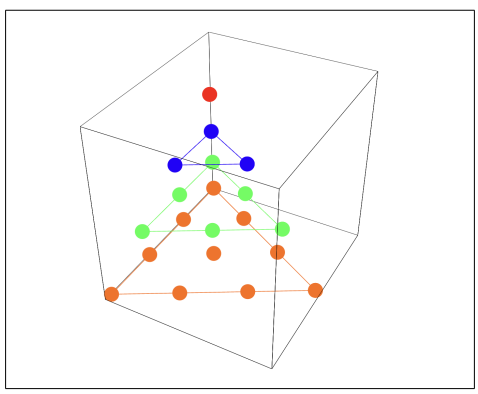

Figure 3: The Tetrahedral Numbers

4 Conclusions

5 Acknowledgements

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